

ANI

CHALLENGES **RASHTRIYA LOK DAL**

- The RLD needs to evaluate why its ground connect consistently fails to yield commensurate electoral dividends, most palpably felt in the defeat after the farmers' agitation
- It is a dilemma for a traditionally community-based party whether to look beyond that base. But some voices advocate that the RLD must look beyond the Jats

seats. We need to relook at our strategy. The party needs to figure out why only about 40 per cent of the Jats voted for us even though we were hoping to bag at least 70 per cent of their votes," says a senior functionary of the RLD. He adds that the party should also think beyond the Jats and find ways to stop being seen as just a 'Jat party'. In the complex caste matrix of western UP, being associated with a politically dominant but numerically modest community perhaps has its downside. Not only does the rest of the landscape unite against you, the Jats themselves have often proved to be not a rock-solid catchment for the RLD, like the Yadavs are for the SP. It may be time to move towards a more pan-community approach.

For the Congress, the UP results not only brought intense disappointment, they also raised a disturbing question mark over party general secretary Priyanka Gandhi's brand value in politics. This was to be her first serious solo plunge into electoral politics. And even if battling the BJP of the Modi-Yogi era is tantamount to jumping off the deep end, the party's worst performance ever in the state's 70-year electoral history is a bitter truth to swallow. Just two seats, down from seven, and a vote share of 2.33 per cent, down from 6.25 per cent—where do you go from here?

While Priyanka's '*Ladki hoon, lad sakti hoon*' experiment of giving 40 per cent tickets to women made headlines, it flopped on the ground with most of the 159 female candidates losing their deposit. This made many in the party question the campaign strategists. However, women weren't the only ones who lost their deposit—it was a fate 387 out of the total 399 Congress candidates met.

Party spokesperson Zishan Haider blamed people close to Priyanka for the poor performance. He was expelled after his statement went viral. "These people have not done anything on the ground and all the leaders who left the party in the recent past did so because of them. I had not said anything against Priyanka, but had blamed a handful of people for misleading her and selling tickets," says Haider.

According to a senior party functionary, the Congress needs to make serious organisational changes in UP if it is keen to survive the 2024 Lok Sabha election. "Otherwise, we will be finished here," he says, adding that the party should also look at forging some sort of tactical understanding with the SP and the RLD ahead of the general election to avoid the splitting of opposition votes.

S.K. Dwivedi, a former professor of political science at Lucknow University, says the Opposition should learn from its mistakes as well as from the BJP's style of booth-level organisation-building. "Opposition leaders should focus on developing a second-line leadership and reworking their strategy to challenge the BJP in the state," he adds. Taking a leaf out of the BJP playbook may be a good place to start. ■

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